

AFRICA INNOVATION AND DEVELOPMENT ACADEMY

(AIDA)

A platform to begin. A community in which to develop. A pathway to bigger academic stages.

ORGANISATIONAL PROFILE

Motto	Research Dialogue Impact
Theme	Innovation for a Prosperous Africa: Ideas Today. A Brighter Tomorrow.
Slogan	Young Minds. Bold Ideas. A Greater Africa.

Who We Are

Africa Innovation and Development Academy (AIDA) is a research-development and academic capacity-building platform created to support generations of researchers. AIDA gives students, young researchers and early-career academics a place to develop ideas, present research, receive constructive feedback, strengthen their skills and build the confidence required to participate in larger academic conferences and scholarly networks.

AIDA is built around a simple idea: talented researchers should not have to wait until they reach a major conference before they have a meaningful opportunity to present, discuss and improve their work. The Academy therefore creates a supportive bridge between learning how to conduct research and participating confidently in the wider academic community.

Why AIDA Exists

Across Africa, many promising research ideas remain inside dissertations, theses and early-stage manuscripts because emerging researchers often lack presentation opportunities, mentorship, scholarly networks and practical publication guidance. For some researchers, the first experience of presenting before an academic audience comes at a high-stakes conference, when there has been little opportunity to practise, receive feedback or refine the work beforehand.

AIDA responds to this gap by creating an accessible academic environment in which researchers can present early ideas, proposals, working papers and completed studies. Feedback is intended to help participants improve the quality of their research while becoming more confident in explaining their methods, defending their arguments and responding to questions.

Our Vision

To become a leading African platform for developing confident, innovative and globally competitive researchers whose research contributes to Africa's development.

Our Mission

To support students and emerging researchers through research presentation, mentorship, capacity building, academic dialogue, networking and collaboration while promoting research and innovation that address Africa's development challenges.

Our Main Aim

AIDA aims to allow young and emerging researchers to develop and present their ideas, build practical research capacity and prepare for larger national, regional and international academic platforms. It also provides guidance to students undertaking research at undergraduate, postgraduate and doctoral levels.

What We Do

Research Presentation Series - Regular online and physical sessions where emerging researchers present research ideas, proposals, working papers or completed studies and receive constructive academic feedback.

Emerging Researchers Conference - A supportive conference platform that allows researchers, including first-time presenters, to experience formal academic presentation and discussion in preparation for larger conferences.

Research Capacity Workshops - Practical sessions on research design, literature review, theory, methodology, data analysis, academic writing, publication, ethics and conference presentation.

Research Clinics - Focused sessions where students and researchers receive guidance on specific research challenges, including research questions, methods, analysis, interpretation and writing.

Mentorship - Opportunities for emerging researchers to learn from experienced academics and researchers on research development, academic careers, publication and conference preparation.

Conference Preparation - Mock presentations and feedback sessions designed to improve slides, research communication, timing, argumentation and responses to likely questions.

Research Dialogue - Conversations bringing together researchers, professionals, policymakers and other stakeholders to examine emerging issues affecting Africa.

Collaboration and Networking - Opportunities to build interdisciplinary and cross-country research relationships, identify co-authors and develop joint projects.

Who We Serve

- Undergraduate students undertaking research projects
- Master's and MPhil students
- Doctoral researchers
- Recent graduates interested in research
- Early-career academics and researchers
- Independent researchers
- Young professionals interested in evidence-based development
- Researchers preparing for academic conferences or publications

Research Focus

AIDA welcomes interdisciplinary work, with particular research interests that can deepen understanding of innovation and African development. Priority areas include:

- Innovation and entrepreneurship
- Digital transformation and artificial intelligence
- Economic development and productivity
- SMEs and enterprise development
- International business and trade
- Employment, skills and the future of work
- Education and human capital
- Finance and financial inclusion
- Climate change, green innovation and sustainability
- Agriculture and food security
- Health and social development
- Gender, youth and inclusive development
- Governance, institutions and public policy

The AIDA Researcher Development Pathway

Stage	What it means
1. Develop	Refine a research idea, question, proposal or early-stage study.
2. Present	Share the work before a supportive academic audience.
3. Receive Feedback	Gain constructive comments from researchers, academics and peers.
4. Strengthen	Improve the research design, analysis, writing and presentation.
5. Prepare	Practise for larger conferences, publication and wider scholarly engagement.
6. Progress	Move confidently to national and international academic platforms.

What Makes AIDA Different

AIDA is not intended to replace universities, research institutions or major academic conferences. Its role is to strengthen the pathway into those spaces. The Academy focuses on development rather than competition: researchers are encouraged to test ideas, learn from feedback, improve their work and gradually build the skills and confidence required for larger scholarly stages.

Our Values

- Academic integrity
- Research excellence
- Innovation
- Inclusion
- Mentorship
- Collaboration
- Professionalism
- Development impact

Our Long-Term Ambition

AIDA seeks to grow into a recognised African research and knowledge platform connecting emerging researchers with established academics, universities, research centres, professional bodies, policymakers and development organisations. Over time, the Academy intends to develop regular seminars, conferences, mentorship programmes, research training, working-paper and policy-brief series, collaborative projects and institutional partnerships across Africa and beyond.

Our Promise

Young Minds. Bold Ideas. A Greater Africa.

AIDA believes that Africa's development will be strengthened when more young researchers have the confidence, skills, networks and opportunities to turn good ideas into credible evidence. Through Research, Dialogue and Impact, the Academy will help emerging researchers move from promising ideas to stronger academic contributions and wider platforms.